DAY 15 | PRE-READ

The Engineer Who Goes to the Problem

A light read before Day 15. About 15 minutes.

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Why read this?

Tomorrow is different. There is less code and more practice: simulations and role plays about the human side of engineering. This short read introduces the role you are training for and the mindset behind it.

1. What is a Forward Deployed Engineer?

Most software engineers build a product for many customers from a distance. A **Forward Deployed Engineer** (FDE) goes to the customer: into their meetings, their systems and their problems. They write real code, connect real data, and stay until the solution works in the customer's world.

Think of a doctor who visits patients at home rather than only seeing them at a clinic. They see how people actually live, which changes what treatment will really work.

2. The mindset in one sentence

> **"This is my problem until the customer's problem is solved."** That is ownership, the heart of the FDE mindset.

Habit	What it looks like
Ownership	Following up on a blocker even when it belongs to another team.
Customer focus	Measuring success by the customer's outcome, not lines of code.
Curiosity	Asking "why?" until the real need appears.
Pragmatism	Choosing the simple solution that works now.
Clear communication	Explaining technical ideas in plain language.

3. Bias towards action

Real projects rarely give you complete information. Waiting for perfect clarity often means waiting forever. A bias towards action means taking a small, safe step that helps you learn, such as a quick prototype or a clarifying question, rather than waiting.

The key skill is telling the difference between decisions that are easy to undo (like choosing a colour for a draft chart) and decisions that are hard to undo (like deleting data). Move quickly on the first kind. Slow down and consult on the second.

4. How tomorrow works

- Short teaching blocks, then practice.
- Simulations in small teams: your first day at a customer, a 30 minute prototype sprint.
- Role plays in pairs: one person is the customer, one is the FDE, then you swap.
- Feedback is kind and specific: one thing that worked, one thing to try next time.

5. Think about these before class

- Recall a time you took ownership of something that was not strictly your job. What happened?
- Recall a time you waited too long for information. What would a small first step have been?
- Who is the best explainer of complex ideas you know? What do they do?

Genba (現場): the actual place where the work happens; go and see for yourself